

The Far East



CHINA IS ONE OF THE LARGEST COUNTRIES in the world. The climate over this vast area is controlled by the wet summer monsoon winds and the bitterly cold winds that blow down from the Arctic in winter. Mountains or desert cover two-thirds of the country, with tropical rainforests in the south. These habitats provide a refuge for some of the world's rarest animals, such as the giant panda and the Siberian tiger. The islands of Japan stretch for more than 1,200 miles (1,900 km) off the east coast of China. Japan has a mild climate, with warm summers, cool winters, and plentiful rainfall. Broadleaved forests cover much of the land.

Sika deer
(*Cervus nippon*)
Height at shoulder:
up to 3 ft 9 in (115 cm)

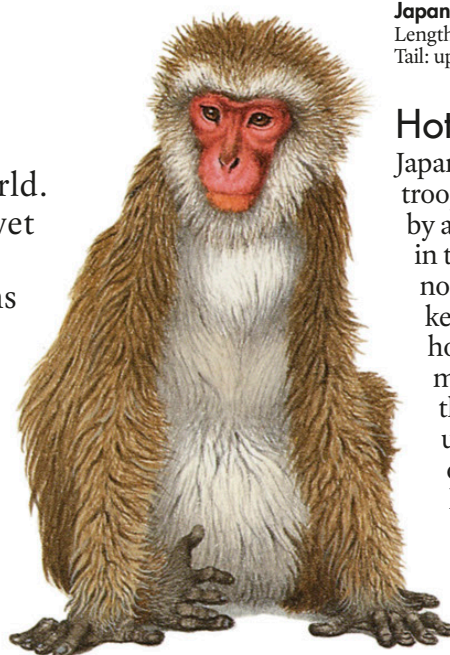


Warning signal

The sika deer has a patch of white fur on its rump that it fluffs up when it is alarmed, acting as a warning signal to others. In summer, the sika deer has a chestnut coat with white spots, which helps camouflage it among the trees. In winter, it grows darker fur and loses most of its spots. Sika deer are hardy animals and have been introduced to forests all over the world.

Bamboo eater

The giant panda feeds mainly on bamboo, spending up to 16 hours a day eating about 600 bamboo stems. Each giant panda lives in its own territory in the misty mountain forests of southwest China. Its thick, waterproof fur helps keep it warm and dry. Baby pandas are pink, blind, and helpless when they are born. They take their first steps at about three months old, but cannot walk well until they are a year old.



Japanese macaque (*Macaca fuscata*)
Length: up to 2 ft 2 in (65 cm)
Tail: up to 3.4 in (8.7 cm)

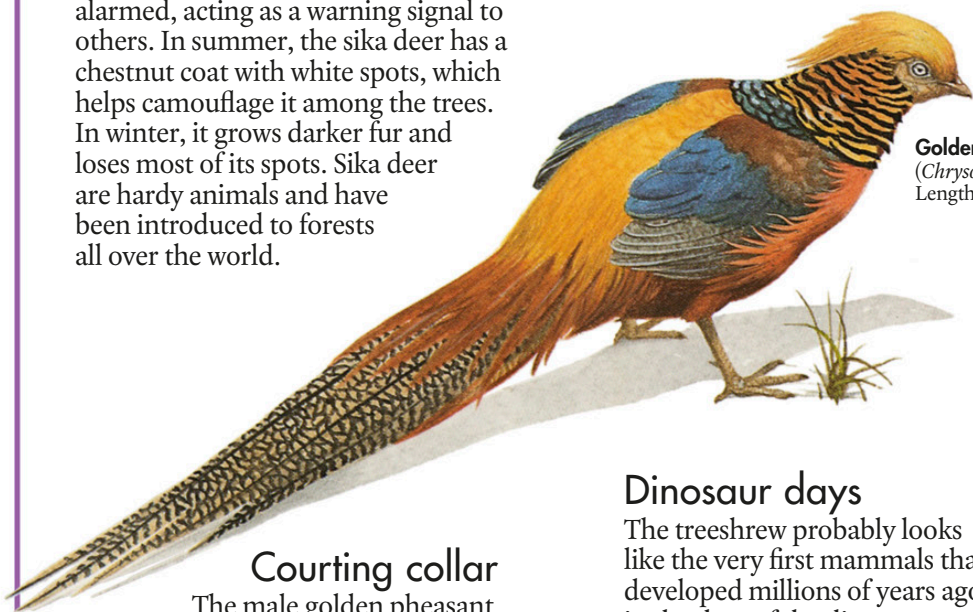
Hot baths

Japanese macaque monkeys live in troops of up to 40 individuals, led by an adult male. Troops that live in the cold, snowy mountains of northern Japan have learned to keep warm in winter by taking hot baths in the volcanic mountain springs. They sit in the springs with hot water right up to their necks. Other troops of this intelligent monkey have learned to wash their food before eating it.



Giant panda
(*Ailuropoda melanoleuca*)
Body length: up to 5 ft 11 in (1.8 m)
Tail: up to 6 in (16 cm)

Golden pheasant
(*Chrysolophus pictus*)
Length: up to 3 ft 9 in (1.15 m)



Courting collar

The male golden pheasant has a brightly colored collar of feathers that he displays to attract a female during courtship. Golden pheasants live in the forests of central China. They nest on the ground, and the female sits on the eggs to keep them warm. The chicks can feed themselves as soon as they hatch, and can fly from about a week old.

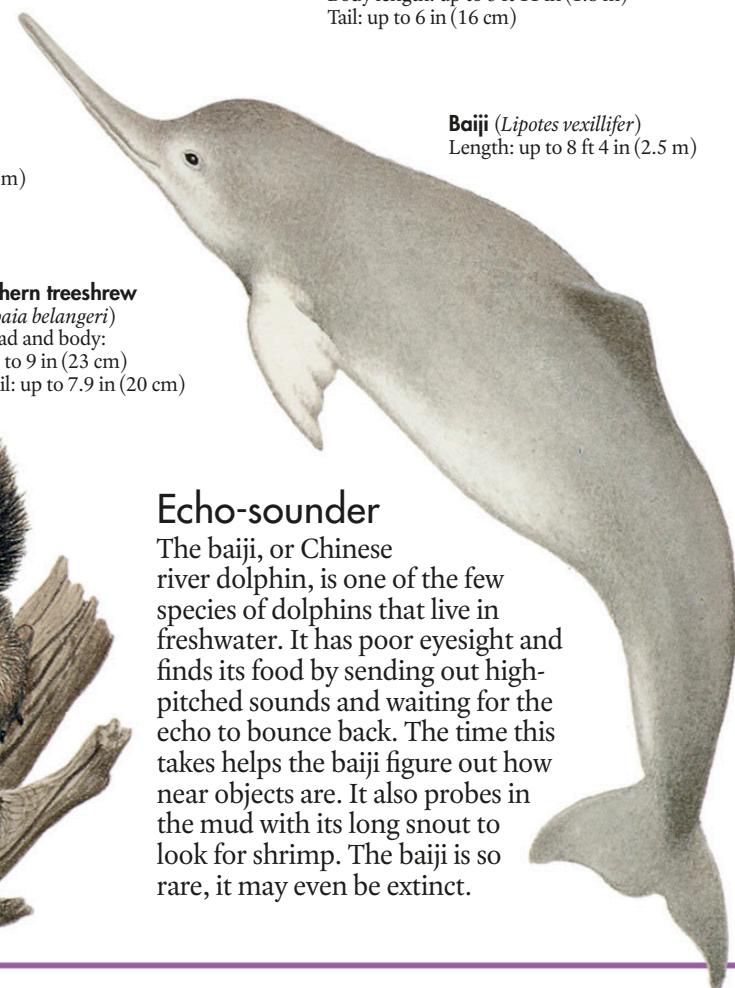
Dinosaur days

The treeshrew probably looks like the very first mammals that developed millions of years ago, in the days of the dinosaurs. Treeshrews live in pairs, building a nest on the ground or among tree roots. The male marks his territory with a strong scent made by glands in his throat.



Northern treeshrew
(*Tupaia belangeri*)
Head and body:
up to 9 in (23 cm)
Tail: up to 7.9 in (20 cm)

Baiji (*Lipotes vexillifer*)
Length: up to 8 ft 4 in (2.5 m)



Echo-sounder

The baiji, or Chinese river dolphin, is one of the few species of dolphins that live in freshwater. It has poor eyesight and finds its food by sending out high-pitched sounds and waiting for the echo to bounce back. The time this takes helps the baiji figure out how near objects are. It also probes in the mud with its long snout to look for shrimp. The baiji is so rare, it may even be extinct.